

SEED LIBRARIES & CLIMATE DATA PRACTICES

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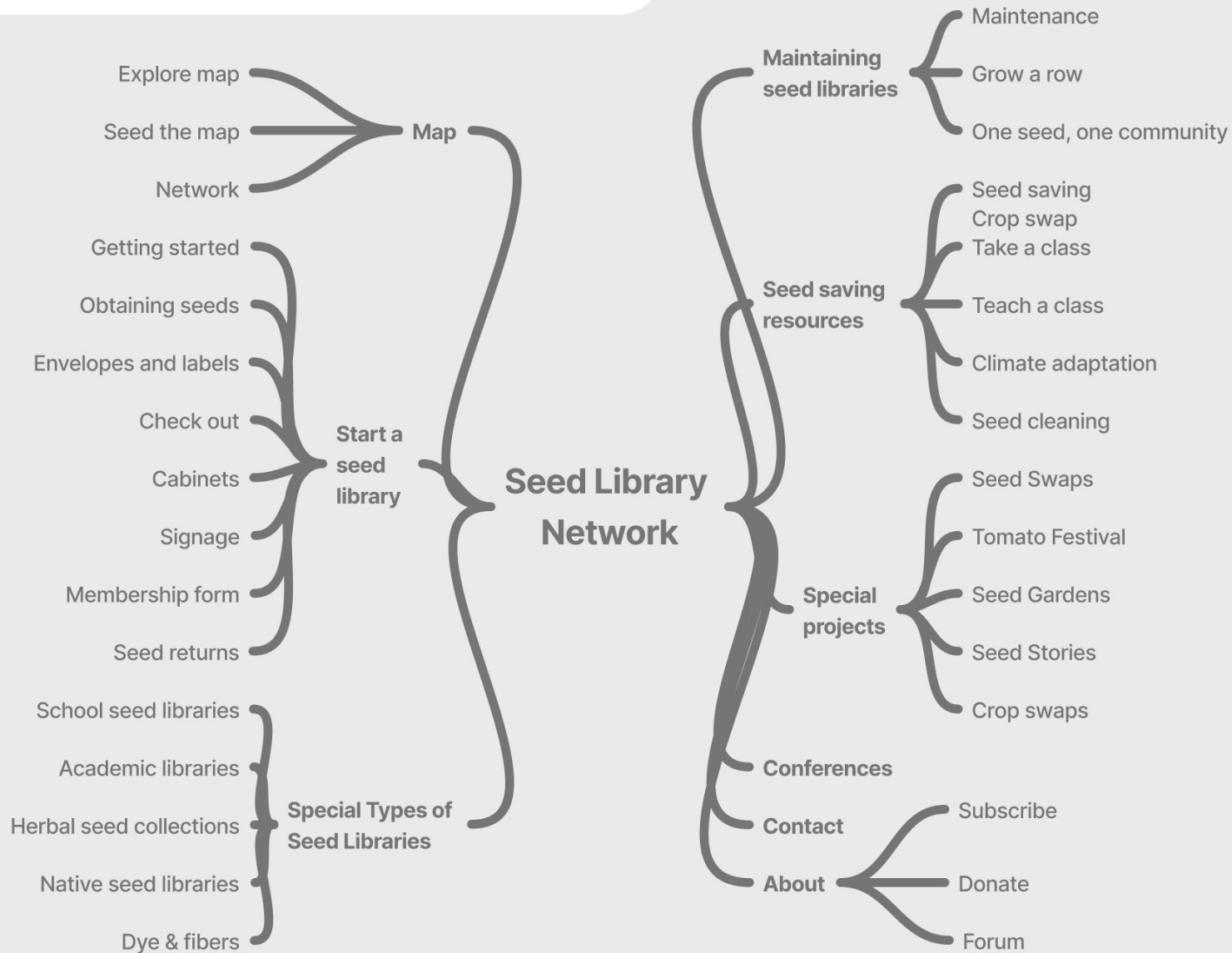
SEED LIBRARIES & CLIMATE DATA PRACTICES

Amidst our global climate crisis, seed saving and sharing initiatives have emerged as a critical site of resistance against state control and commodification of genetic diversity. For millennia, heirloom seeds have been a vital part of our commons, freely collected and shared across generations and geographies. However, mass dispossession of agricultural land, large-scale monoculture farms, neoliberal economic and juridical agreements, and the privatization of seeds have threatened the survival of heirloom varieties and foodways that are fundamental for climate resilience in our food systems, particularly for BIPOC and frontline communities across the Global Majority. In response, autonomous and decentralized seed sharing networks, such as seed libraries, seek to safeguard and share locally-adapted heirloom seeds. Home scale seed saving and sharing often becomes one of the last remaining avenues to preserve culturally-important and threatened varieties of plants no longer cultivated in their place of origin, particularly for migrant and diasporic communities.

Seed saving and sharing networks offers CSCW the opportunity to interrogate a place-based, human-scale climate data practice from the perspective of BIPOC and frontline communities experiencing inequitable impacts of climate oppression. Seeds themselves, along with their stewards, encode unique climate information about the territories and lineages of its past and present. Seed stewards cultivate intimate relationships to territories and temporalities, attuning to the conditions of the land, following the entire life cycle of a plant from seed to seed, and adapting to changing climate conditions. More importantly, seed libraries serve as autonomous spaces to practice prefigurative politics, facilitating intergenerational knowledge sharing of traditional foodways and support multispecies collaboration with the more-than-human world across time and geographies. Thus, seed saving quickly becomes entangled with greater political demands like land access, Indigeneous sovereignty, and resistance against state and market power that threatens the continuance of this work.

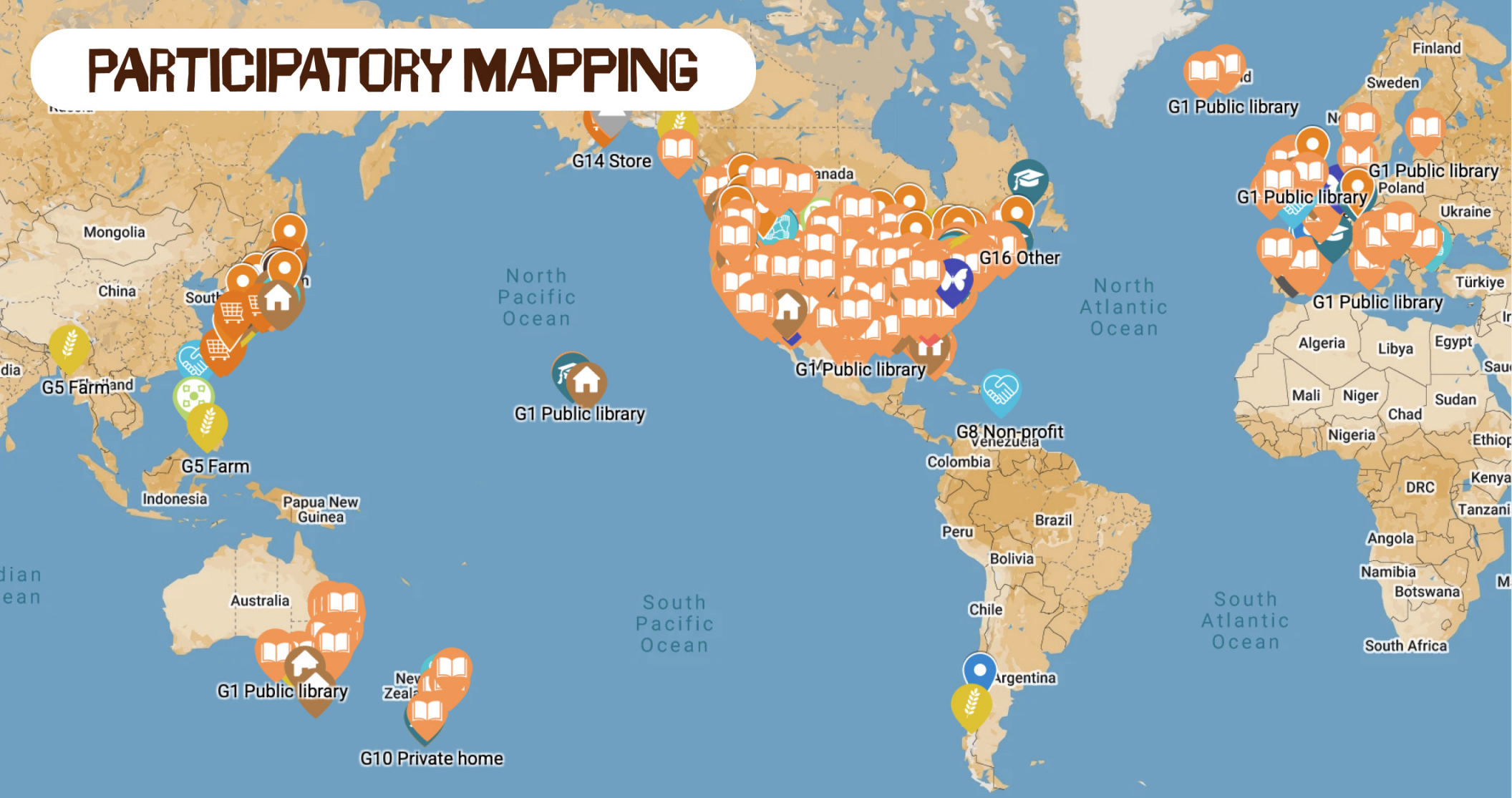
This provocation seeks to explore research opportunities within the seed saving movement, particularly the potential impact of new technologies in raising awareness and increasing participation in seed sharing networks. The zine covers seed packets as a site of knowledge production and storytelling, participatory maps as place-based resistance, and open-source educational materials that increase access to the digital commons. Participatory design and research methods can help us better analyze and learn from the social, material, and ecological power of grassroots, community-led, and volunteer-based collective forms of self-organization rooted in care and generosity against a changing climate.

SEED LIBRARY NETWORK



In the early 2000s, local seed stewards started the Bay Area Seed Interchange Library, which kickstarted the seed saving and sharing movement around the world. Today, the Seed Library Network (seedlibrarynetwork.org) manages a global seed library census and maintains a database of over 1,000 seed libraries across different domains, including seed libraries that are situated within public libraries, schools and universities, nonprofits, urban gardens, and Indigenous and diasporic communities. The Seed Library Network also publishes a wide range of different open-source digital resources and tools to increase participation in seed libraries, including educational materials, participatory maps, and public forums. An information architecture of the website is shown above.

PARTICIPATORY MAPPING



Started in December 2023, the Seed Library Census is a grassroots initiative to create a participatory map of seed libraries around the world. The first part of the survey asks for location and contact information, year opened, mission and vision statements, and type of seed library, while the optional second part asks more detailed survey information about the volume of local seeds, methods to ensure seed quality, important values, inventory systems, information resources, programming, support needed, and additional information.

Responses from the census populates a custom Google Map with markers for each seed library around the world. The icon indicates the type of library, and after clicking on the pin, users will be able to see information about the location, contact information, website, mission and vision statements, year opened, and a photo of the seed library. The map is also searchable and can easily be shared or embedded onto other websites. Currently there are contributions across the US, Central and South America, Europe, Asia, and Australia, and the map can be divided between English, French, Spanish, and Japanese submissions. As of May 2026, there have been almost 200,000 unique views of this participatory map. There are also other regional maps built by other seed library communities that focus on different states, countries, and regions around the world, from the East Bay of California and Mangakino of Aotearoa to Japan and Moldova.

MISSION STATEMENTS



Above is a word cloud generated from the 404 US-based libraries that submitted a mission or vision statement in the census, giving a general overview of how seed librarians are describing their seed saving and seed sharing practices, with an emphasis on gardens, growing food, sharing, and community.

SEED LIBRARY EXAMPLES



A collection of seed libraries in universities, public libraries, and individual homes across the San Francisco Bay Area that offer seeds freely to the community.

The Earthseed Dome at the Institute of Contemporary Art in San Francisco is a seed library embedded within a public art installation that offers free native wildflower seed packets to visitors.

SEED PACKET DESIGNS



Seed stewards often use coin envelopes as a canvas to share intimate stories of their connection to plant relatives for the next seed keeper, passing down genetic information, care instructions, and artistic inspiration through linocut stamps, cyanotype prints, and handwritten notes. These seed packets serve as a critical site of human-scale, place-based knowledge production, storytelling, and resistance outside of state and market control. Participatory design methods help us better understand how frontline communities use both digital and analog tools to organize autonomous seed sharing networks like free seed libraries to preserve genetic diversity and safeguard our environmental commons.

OPEN SOURCE RESOURCES

Membership Form

All seeds are free. There is no requirement to return seeds.

[Sign in to Google](#) to save your progress. [Learn more](#)

* Indicates required question

Email *

Your email

First name *

Your answer

Last Name

Your answer

Stay connected: Would you like to be contacted about seed swaps, classes, etc? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

I agree to the Safe Seed Promise.

Embrace Diversity!

Diversity will allow us to breed for a changing climate, adverse conditions, & community preferences.

Very likely as labelled (self pollinating)	Common beans, peas, sweet peas, lettuce, tomatoes, wheat, arugula?
Possibly diverse (If more than one variety of the species was planted together)	Fava beans, runner beans, chard/beets* (same species), eggplant, peppers, okra, onions*
Very likely diverse (hard for home gardeners to maintain a variety)	Corn, squash, melons, cucumbers, carrots*, brassicas** (Broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, collards, kale, & kohlrabi are all the same species!) radish*, sunflowers*, onion*

* Arugula is insect-pollinated, but due to few varieties in gardens will likely be as labeled.
* Avoid commercial hybrids, which may be bred for male sterility.
* Save from at least 5 plants or may not be viable.

For more resources, visit www.seedlibrarynetwork.org Email us: hello@seedlibrarynetwork.org

How Much?

QUANTITIES

- ✓ Take only what you plan to grow
- ✓ 2-3 seeds/plant for larger seeds
- ✓ A pinch for smaller seeds

SeedLibraryNetwork.org

Argula

Your Name: 2024

How to Plant

Full or part sun
Depth: 0.5 cm (1/4")
Spacing: 20 cm (8")
Best months for planting for seed: early spring
Seed life: 9 years

How to Save Seeds

Cut stems when pods turn brown and hard. Save from multiple, healthy plants. Put stems in a labeled paper bag until you're ready to clean or drop off. Label with the common name + variety + year + town + your name

Automatic Seed Wrapper

Made by Brandon Rehm (<https://www.linkedin.com/in/brandon102402/>) for the Brown County, Wisconsin, USA Seed Library (Last Updated: 1/14/2023). Big shout out to Nancy Rehm for creating multiple versions of the modified seed wrapper and to Julia Dahn who assisted with the seed saving dropdown menu.

Instructions

Step 1:
Input all seed data in the "Information" sheet.

Step 2:
Go to "Generator" sheet and change the seed number to print from the "Seed Number" column row in the "Information" sheet.

Step 3:
For 8.5x11, go to 8.5x11 sheet and print it with these parameters:
-Portrait Orientation
-Scale 100%
-Custom Margins (1" All Around)
-8.5x11"
-Print however many copies you need.
-Only print the "8.5x11" sheet.

Test: For A4 - Avery, go to the "A4 - 8 labels/sheet - Avery" sheet and print it with these parameters:
-Scale "Fit to page"
-Custom Margins
-1/8" 0.18 Inches
-Top 0.51 Inches
-Bottom 0.50 Inches
-Center Alignment (Horizontally and Vertically)
-A4
-Print however many copies you need.
-Only print the "A4 - 8 labels/sheet - Avery" sheet.

GUARDAR SEMENTES DE FEIJÃO

The Seed Library Network (SLN) serves as an accessible online platform for seed librarians and stewards to access and adapt free and open-source resources for their seed saving and exchange activities. The website itself shares different educational resources and materials to support others in building a new seed library and running different seed saving and sharing initiatives. SLN provides downloadable and editable resources in different languages (English, Spanish, French, and Portuguese) hosted on Google Docs and Canva, including membership forms, signs, zines, and seed packet labels. In addition, SLN also collects and publishes community resources to share on the website through an Airtable form, and hosts a public forum where users can ask questions and discuss all things related to seed saving and sharing. All digital resources are part of the public domain.

SEED SHARING NETWORKS & PROGRAMMING

Seed sharing networks host a wide variety of events to engage BIPOC and frontline communities in-person, including seed saving workshops, seed packing parties, and seed swap events, often with an emphasis on culturally-relevant varieties. Creating spaces outside of state and market control demonstrates the social and material power of grassroots, community-led, and volunteer-based collective forms of self-organization rooted in care and generosity against a changing climate.



